principle, it is difficult to impose a different set of rules for those down the line. The deep paradox remained that Rahul could not radically alter the Congress and yet insist on quasi-royal status for himself—the road to genuine glasnost would have to include his own abdication. He may have genuinely wanted to change the organizational structure, but in a party as old as the Congress, as ossified and as crowded with big egos, rival camps, an entrenched old guard and byzantine intrigue, no quick fixes were possible.

But the problem was not just with the Congress party—it was also with the method adopted by Rahul Gandhi to try and effect change. In her book, *Decoding Rahul Gandhi*, author Aarthi Ramachandran claims that Rahul Gandhi wanted to adopt a Japanese style of management to revamp the NSUI and Youth Congress. 'The Toyota Way' is how Gandhi saw the future, urging his team to develop the right 'processes' and 'systems' which would make standardization of practices possible. Apparently, a few of his team members were even sent to the Toyota factory in Japan to get first-hand experience of how the auto company was able to arrive at a zero-error system of production.

Rahul Gandhi failed to recognize that a political party is not a corporate house. Business practices that worked in the automobile industry simply could not be replicated in the Congress party. A senior MLA from Maharashtra told me how he had to wait almost a month in Delhi for an appointment with Rahul. 'In a business, you can interact on the computer. In a political party, there must be direct contact. What is the point of having a "system" when I cannot even get access to my leader? A party worker feels on top of the world when his leader talks to him; he doesn't want to be told to fill in a form first and wait in a queue!' The frustrated politician later joined Sharad Pawar's National Congress Party (NCP). In fact, more than one Congressman complained that if they rang up Rahul's office, they would be put through to a voice recording machine.

The people chosen by Rahul Gandhi to implement his agenda reflected a desire to have strategic consultants, management-oriented corporate types and well-meaning scholars around him rather than full-time politicians. The